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MATH 455: Partial Differential Equations

Assignment #5 - Laplace's Equation
Due Thursday, November 5, 2026

1. (14 points) Let $a, b > 0$ and $g \in \mathrm{PC}^1[0, a]$ be given. Find the solution $u(x, y)$ of

$$\Delta u = 0$$

on the rectangle $\Omega = [0, a] \times [0, b]$, with

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial x}(0, y) = \frac{\partial u}{\partial x}(a, y) = 0$$

for $0 < y < b$ and

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial y}(x, 0) = 0 \qquad \text{and} \qquad u(x, b) = g(x)$$

for $0 < x < a$.
Hint: It might be easiest to use sinh and cosh in some places rather than real exponentials.

Solution —

$$\Delta u = 0 \implies \frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2} + \frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial y^2} = 0$$

Since this is a linear PDE, we proceed with separation of variables, assuming the solution takes the (separated) form $u(x, y) = X(x)Y(y)$

$$\implies X''(x)Y(y) = -X(x)Y''(y)$$
$$\implies \frac{X''(x)}{X(x)} = -\frac{Y''(y)}{Y(y)} = \lambda$$

This equation takes the form $F(x) = G(y)$ for all $x, y \implies$ both must be equal to some constant λ (fix $x = x_0$, and then $F(x_0) = G(y)$ for all $y \implies G(y)$ is constant $\implies F(x)$ is constant since they're equal to each other). This yields the two ordinary differential equations

$$\begin{cases} X'' - \lambda X = 0 \\ Y'' + \lambda Y = 0 \end{cases}$$

whose solutions depend on the sign of λ.

For $\lambda < 0$:

$$X(x) = c_0 \cos\left(\sqrt{-\lambda}x\right) + c_1 \sin\left(\sqrt{-\lambda}x\right) \qquad Y(y) = c_2 e^{\sqrt{-\lambda}y} + c_3 e^{-\sqrt{-\lambda}y}$$

For $\lambda = 0$:

$$X(x) = Ax + B \qquad Y(y) = Cy + D$$

For $\lambda > 0$:

$$X(x) = c_4 e^{\sqrt{\lambda}x} + c_5 e^{-\sqrt{\lambda}x} \qquad Y(y) = c_6 \cos\left(\sqrt{\lambda}y\right) + c_7 \sin\left(\sqrt{\lambda}y\right)$$

We apply the boundary conditions to $u(x, y) = X(x)Y(y)$:

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial u}{\partial x}(0, y) = 0 &\implies X'(0)Y(y) = 0 \\ &\implies X'(0) = 0 \quad (\text{For } Y(y) \neq 0) \end{aligned}$$

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial u}{\partial x}(a, y) = 0 &\implies X'(a)Y(y) = 0 \\ &\implies X'(a) = 0 \quad (\text{For } Y(y) \neq 0) \end{aligned}$$

We use these results to constrain the unknown constants in our separated solutions:

For $\lambda < 0$:

$$\begin{aligned} X'(0) = 0 &\implies \sqrt{-\lambda}c_1 = 0 \\ &\implies \boxed{c_1 = 0} \\ X'(a) = 0 &\implies -\sqrt{-\lambda}c_0 \sin\left(\sqrt{-\lambda}a\right) = 0 \\ &\implies \sin\left(\sqrt{-\lambda}a\right) = 0 \quad (\text{for nontrivial solution with } c_0 \neq 0) \\ &\implies \sqrt{-\lambda}a = n\pi \quad \text{for } n \in \mathbb{Z} \\ &\implies \boxed{\lambda = -\left(\frac{n\pi}{a}\right)^2} \end{aligned}$$

For $\lambda = 0$:

$$X'(0) = 0, X'(a) = 0 \implies \boxed{A = 0}$$

For $\lambda > 0$:

$$\begin{aligned}
X'(0) = 0 &\implies \sqrt{\lambda}c_4 - \sqrt{\lambda}c_5 = 0 \\
&\implies \boxed{c_4 = c_5} \\
X'(a) = 0 &\implies \sqrt{\lambda}c_4 e^{\sqrt{\lambda}a} - \sqrt{\lambda}c_5 e^{-\sqrt{\lambda}a} = 0 \\
&\implies \sqrt{\lambda}c_4 \left(\underbrace{e^{\sqrt{\lambda}a} - e^{-\sqrt{\lambda}a}}_{\neq 0} \right) = 0 \quad (\text{using } c_4 = c_5) \\
&\implies \boxed{c_4 = 0}
\end{aligned}$$

This leads us to general separated solutions:

For $\lambda < 0$:

$$u(x, y) = \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{a}\right)\left(A_n e^{\frac{n\pi y}{a}} + B_n e^{-\frac{n\pi y}{a}}\right)$$

For $\lambda = 0$:

$$u(x, y) = \alpha y + \beta$$

For $\lambda > 0$:

$$u(x, y) = 0$$

Hence the general vertically-constrained solution is the superposition of all these separated solutions:

$$u(x, y) = \alpha y + \beta + \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{a}\right)\left(A_n e^{\frac{n\pi y}{a}} + B_n e^{-\frac{n\pi y}{a}}\right)$$

We proceed to apply the horizontal boundary conditions.

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial y}(x,0) = 0 \implies \alpha + \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{n\pi}{a} \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{a}\right) \left(A_n e^{\frac{n\pi y}{a}} - B_n e^{-\frac{n\pi y}{a}}\right)\Bigg|_{(x,0)} = 0$$

$$\implies \alpha + \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \frac{n\pi}{a}(A_n - B_n) \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{a}\right) = 0$$

Hence α is the constant term and each $n\pi(A_n - B_n)/a$ is the Fourier coefficient of the cosine expansion of $f(x) = 0$ on $x \in [0, a]$. Since the average value of this function is 0 everyone, we have that $\boxed{\alpha = 0}$. Also,

$$\implies \frac{n\pi(A_n - B_n)}{a} = \frac{2}{a} \int_0^a (-\alpha) \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{a}\right) dx$$

$$\implies (A_n - B_n) = -\frac{2\alpha}{n\pi} \int_0^a \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{a}\right) dx = 0$$

$$\implies \boxed{A_n = B_n}$$

Hence we can write the solution as

$$u(x,y) = \beta + 2\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} C_n \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{a}\right) \cosh\left(\frac{n\pi y}{a}\right)$$

We apply the final boundary condition

$$u(x,b) = g(x) \implies \beta + 2\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} C_n \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{a}\right) \cosh\left(\frac{n\pi b}{a}\right) = g(x)$$

$$\implies g(x) = \beta + \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \left[\underbrace{2C_n \cosh\left(\frac{n\pi b}{a}\right)}_{\zeta_n}\right] \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{a}\right)$$

$$\implies g(x) = \beta + \sum_{n=1}^{\infty} \zeta_n \cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{a}\right)$$

Which is the cosine-expansion of $g(x)$ on $[0, a]$, with β being the average value of $g(x)$ on $[0, a]$. Hence

$$\boxed{\beta = \frac{1}{a} \int_0^a g(x) dx}$$

And

$$\zeta_n = \frac{2}{a}\int_0^a g(x)\cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{a}\right)dx$$
$$\implies 2C_n\cosh\left(\frac{n\pi b}{a}\right) = \frac{2}{a}\int_0^a g(x)\cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{a}\right)dx$$
$$\implies \boxed{C_n = \frac{1}{a}\operatorname{sech}\left(\frac{n\pi b}{a}\right)\int_0^a g(x)\cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{a}\right)dx}$$

In the general solution

$$\boxed{u(x,y) = \beta + 2\sum_{n=1}^{\infty} C_n\cos\left(\frac{n\pi x}{a}\right)\cosh\left(\frac{n\pi y}{a}\right)}$$

2. (16 points) Let $a > 0$ be given and find (using polar coordinates) the solution $u(r,\theta)$ of Laplace's equation

$$\Delta u = 0$$

on the wedge

$$\Omega = \left\{(r,\theta) : 0 \le r < a, 0 \le \theta \le \frac{\pi}{3}\right\}$$

with

$$u(r,0) = u\left(r,\frac{\pi}{3}\right) = 0$$

for $0 \le r < a$ and

$$u(a,\theta) = a^2$$

for $0 \le \theta \le \frac{\pi}{3}$. In particular, make sure to only find solutions that remain bounded as $r \to 0$.

Solution — Using polar coordinates conveniently transforms the (non-uniform) boundary of the wedge to a uniform boundary (a rectangle) in polar space. Hence, we must also express the laplace equation in polar form. We apply the change-of-variables

$$x(r,\theta) = r\cos\theta \qquad y(r,\theta) = r\sin\theta$$

And express

$$u(x,y) \implies u(r,\theta)$$

keeping in mind that r and θ are both functions of x and y. We proceed to find $\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2}$ and $\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial y^2}$ in terms of θ and r.

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial x} = \frac{\partial u}{\partial r}\frac{\partial r}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial u}{\partial \theta}\frac{\partial \theta}{\partial x}$$

To find $\frac{\partial r}{\partial x}$ we need r as a function of x and y : $r(x,y)$. We use

$$\begin{aligned} r^2 = x^2 + y^2 &\implies 2r\frac{\partial r}{\partial x} = 2x \\ &\implies \frac{\partial r}{\partial x} = \frac{x}{r} \\ &\implies \boxed{\frac{\partial r}{\partial x} = \cos\theta} \end{aligned}$$

To find $\frac{\partial \theta}{\partial x}$ we need $\theta(x,y)$. We use

$$\begin{aligned} \tan\theta = \frac{y}{x} &\implies \sec^2\theta\frac{\partial \theta}{\partial x} = -\frac{y}{x^2} \\ &\implies \frac{\partial \theta}{\partial x} = -\cos^2\theta\frac{y}{x^2} \\ &\implies \frac{\partial \theta}{\partial x} = -\cos^2\theta\frac{r\sin\theta}{(r\cos\theta)^2} \\ &\implies \boxed{\frac{\partial \theta}{\partial x} = -\frac{\sin\theta}{r}} \end{aligned}$$

Hence

$$\frac{\partial u}{\partial x} = \cos\theta\frac{\partial u}{\partial r} - \frac{\sin\theta}{r}\frac{\partial u}{\partial \theta}$$

And

$$\begin{aligned} \frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2} &= \frac{\partial}{\partial x}\left(\cos\theta\frac{\partial u}{\partial r} - \frac{\sin\theta}{r}\frac{\partial u}{\partial \theta}\right) \\ &= \underbrace{\frac{\partial(\cos\theta)}{\partial x}}_{\text{A}}\frac{\partial u}{\partial r} + \cos\theta\underbrace{\frac{\partial}{\partial x}\frac{\partial u}{\partial r}}_{\text{B}} - \underbrace{\frac{\partial(\frac{\sin\theta}{r})}{\partial x}}_{\text{C}}\frac{\partial u}{\partial \theta} - \frac{\sin\theta}{r}\underbrace{\frac{\partial}{\partial x}\frac{\partial u}{\partial \theta}}_{\text{D}} \end{aligned}$$

Simplifying these four pieces:

A:

$$\frac{\partial(\cos\theta)}{\partial x} = \frac{\partial}{\partial x}\left(\frac{x}{\sqrt{x^2+y^2}}\right)$$

$$= \frac{\sqrt{x^2+y^2} - \frac{x^2}{\sqrt{x^2+y^2}}}{x^2+y^2}$$

$$= \frac{r - r\cos^2\theta}{r^2}$$

$$= \frac{\sin^2\theta}{r}$$

B: Note that $\partial u/\partial r$ is some function of r, θ, so let's temporarily define it as the dummy function $\phi(r, \theta)$. Hence,

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial x}\frac{\partial u}{\partial r} = \frac{\partial}{\partial x}\phi(r,\theta)$$

$$= \frac{\partial\phi}{\partial r}\frac{\partial r}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial\phi}{\partial\theta}\frac{\partial\theta}{\partial x}$$

$$= \frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial r^2}\frac{\partial r}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial\theta\partial r}\frac{\partial\theta}{\partial x}$$

$$= \cos\theta\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial r^2} - \frac{\sin\theta}{r}\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial\theta\partial r}$$

C:

$$\frac{\partial(\frac{\sin\theta}{r})}{\partial x} = \frac{\partial}{\partial x}\left(\frac{y}{x^2+y^2}\right)$$

$$= \frac{-2xy}{(x^2+y^2)^2}$$

$$= \frac{-2r^2\sin\theta\cos\theta}{r^4}$$

$$= \frac{-2\sin\theta\cos\theta}{r^2}$$

$$= -\frac{\sin 2\theta}{r^2}$$

D: Note that $\partial u/\partial\theta$ is some function r, θ, so let's also temporarily define it as the dummy function $\phi(r,\theta)$. Then

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial x}\frac{\partial u}{\partial \theta} = \frac{\partial}{\partial x}\phi(r,\theta)$$

$$= \frac{\partial\phi}{\partial r}\frac{\partial r}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial\phi}{\partial\theta}\frac{\partial\theta}{\partial x}$$

$$= \frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial r\partial\theta}\frac{\partial r}{\partial x} + \frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial\theta^2}\frac{\partial\theta}{\partial x}$$

$$= \cos\theta\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial r\partial\theta} - \frac{\sin\theta}{r}\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial\theta^2}$$

Hence

$$\begin{aligned}\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2} =& \frac{\sin^2\theta}{r}\frac{\partial u}{\partial r} + \cos\theta\left[\cos\theta\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial r^2} - \frac{\sin\theta}{r}\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial\theta\partial r}\right] \\ &+ \frac{\sin 2\theta}{r^2}\frac{\partial u}{\partial\theta} - \frac{\sin\theta}{r}\left[\cos\theta\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial r\partial\theta} - \frac{\sin\theta}{r}\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial\theta^2}\right]\end{aligned}$$

$$\boxed{\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial x^2} = \cos^2\theta\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial r^2} + \frac{\sin^2\theta}{r}\frac{\partial u}{\partial r} - \frac{\sin 2\theta}{r}\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial r\partial\theta} + \frac{\sin^2\theta}{r^2}\frac{\partial^2 u}{\partial\theta^2} + \frac{\sin 2\theta}{r^2}\frac{\partial u}{\partial\theta}}$$

3. (20 points) Let $0 < R_1 < R_2$ be given and g be a PC^1 function. Find the single-valued solution of Laplace's equation on the annulus

$$\Omega = \{(r, \theta) : R_1 < r < R_2, -\pi \leq \theta < \pi\}$$

with the boundary conditions

$$u(R_1, \theta) = 0 \qquad \text{and} \qquad u(R_2, \theta) = g(\theta)$$

for $-\pi \leq \theta < \pi$. In particular, use the periodic boundary conditions

$$u(r, -\pi) = u(r, \pi) \qquad \text{and} \qquad \frac{\partial u}{\partial \theta}(r, -\pi) = \frac{\partial u}{\partial \theta}(r, \pi)$$

for $R_1 < r < R_2$ in order to compute the solution.